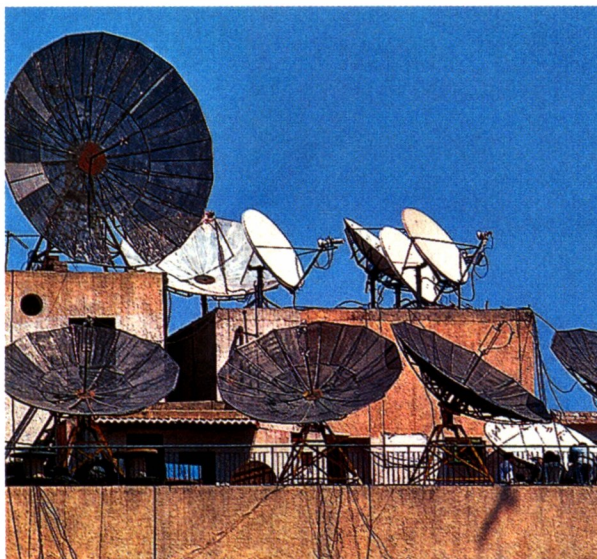


1 Connecting People Telecom Revolution, 1984

A sceptical government gave Sam Pitroda, the founder and chairman of the Centre for Development of Telematics (C-DOT), a budget of Rs 36 crore and 36 months to develop indigenous technology for a digital electronic telephone exchange in the country (INDIA TODAY, October 1984). He did so successfully and laid the foundation of the telecom infrastructure. For every telephone line, a normal international system cost Rs 9,000, while Pitroda's C-DOT system cost just Rs 4,000 (INDIA TODAY, November 1987). The coin-dropping PCOS, a device that generated an instant bill at the user's end, created by Pitroda and his team were a great hit. He was appointed adviser to prime minister Rajiv Gandhi as a reward for his work at C-DOT.

2 Casting A Spell Cable Television, 1991

In 1985, there were less than 150 cable TV operators, but the number rose to over 75 million satellite- and cable-connected homes in 1990 (INDIA TODAY, November 1990). In 1991, people booked hotel rooms to watch the Gulf War on CNN. With channel wars intensifying, the race to seduce the viewers became a game of innovations, city specific channels and area-specific programmes the ploy (INDIA TODAY, February 1996).



YASBANT NEGI

4 Toiling Game First Tollway, 1995

Financed by a quasi-government investor, the 12-km-long tollway linking Indore to Pithampur in Madhya Pradesh reduced the distance by 10 km and curtailed travel time by 45 minutes. Encouraged by the success of the tollway that had a daily collection of Rs 20,000, projects at other industrial centres like Bhopal-Indore were fired up. (INDIA TODAY, March 1995).

5 Celling Success Mobile Phones, 1995

The first call made by West Bengal chief minister Jyoti Basu to communications minister Sukh Ram was a small beginning, but a giant leap for the way people would talk in future. The cellphone became a must-have toy (INDIA TODAY, March 1995). Ten years later, the cellphone became indispensable. If you left home without it, you'd feel you left an organ or limb behind (INDIA TODAY, December 2005). Now, the call rates have dropped sharply from Rs 8 a minute in 1995 to 50 paise per minute, the cheapest in the world.

SANJIT SEN



10

infrastructure successes

The setting up of the telecom infrastructure, the incredible makeover of the Indian Railways, and a dream ride for harried commuters in the Metro. Ten small steps, but one giant stride.

3 Flying Start Private Airlines, 1991

With the open skies policy in 1991, the aviation industry was expected to zoom to new heights, said INDIA TODAY in January 1992. Two years later, private airlines cornered 44 per cent of the passenger traffic. Cut-throat price wars paved a smoother path with Jet Airways taking over Air Sahara, the Air India and Indian merger, and UB Holdings buying a 26 per cent stake in Air Deccan. Now, the share of private airlines in domestic air travel routes is 80.8 per cent.